

# CLASH OF THE RED BRIGADE

**Fisticuffs at the state meet show the punishment meted out to Achuthanandan and Vijayan has had little effect on the cadres**

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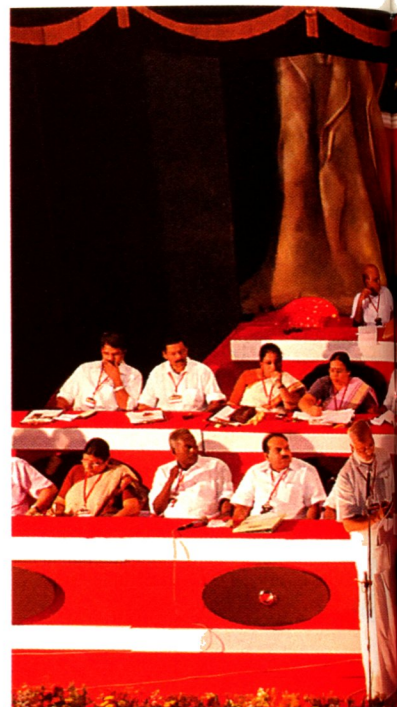
A meeting of the state committee of the CPI(M) normally is as electrifying as Sunday morning mass at the nearby parish. However, it was a different sight last week when thousands of flag-holding workers converged for a mammoth public rally to mark the end of the four-day Kerala state conference at the rain-drenched Nehru Stadium in Kottayam—a prelude to the 19th party congress in March at Coimbatore. A section of the audience cheered, danced and vociferously shouted “VS Zindabad” as Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan got up to address the meeting. As the light drizzle turned into a thunder shower, the comrades rolled up their lungis and let their hair down, boogieing the evening away. In the melee, a few bottles were thrown onto the dais by tipsy comrades. In the iron-fisted Marxist establishment, this was blasphemy.

No sooner had Achuthanandan ended his speech, the newly re-elected state Secretary Pinarayi Vijayan rushed to the stage, seething with rage. “Is this a communist rally or an Usha Uthup rock show that you dance and revel like this?” said Vijayan and told the volunteers to rein in the bad hats. Uthup later took exception to the remark forcing Vijayan to clarify that he meant no offence. As the army of red volunteers began thrashing the unruly comrades, a free for all had ensued, forcing the cancellation of the rally.

Never in its 44-year-old history has CPI(M) witnessed anything as

unruly as this. The VS loyalists were evidently proving a point: “even though our leader is marginalised in the party, we the common ranks are with him”. The state conference had expectedly reaffirmed the official camp’s dominance of the organisation against Achuthanandan’s minority faction. Vijayan, 64, was re-elected—for the fourth time in a row—unanimously as the state secretary by the 500-odd delegates. An 85-member state committee was also elected, unanimously, in which too the official camp retained its massive majority. Among the 11 new faces inducted into the committee, just one belonged to the VS camp. All the proceedings were conducted under the close supervision of five Politburo members including Prakash Karat and Sitaram Yechury so that the factional war did not come to the fore. “The cancer of factionalism affecting the party for more than a decade will come to an end with this meeting,” said Vijayan. Karat warned with dire consequences if factionalism resurfaced in any form.

It was clear that the 84-year-old chief minister would come for some heavy treatment at the conference for the vast majority of the 500-odd delegates, who came from the districts, be-



longed to the chief minister’s rival camp. Achuthanandan’s rivals had established clear majority in the party district committees by winning 11 of the 14 districts at conferences held in the past few months. Most of the delegates blasted Achuthanandan—the only surviving founder member of CPI(M) in Kerala—for various lapses. The organisational report, adopted finally by the state conference, was conspicuous for the barbs against the chief minister. Though the report lauded his role in the party’s victory in the last Assembly polls, it criticised him saying that as chief minister he had failed to defend his cabinet colleagues—mostly from the rival camp—when they faced

**The ‘spirited’ clash between the supporters of the rival factions showed how little control leaders have over cadres.**

